Middle East Daily Briefing

July 18, 2026

- **Reporting window:** ~24 hours, July 17, 08:30 to July 18, 08:00 KST
- **Overall assessment:** The infrastructure phase began early, and on both sides at once. On a seventh straight night the US struck six bridges in Hormozgan, a Bandar Abbas rail junction and the Chabahar port control tower — executing the "bridges" half of the July 22 ultimatum five days ahead of schedule (IND-20260716-1 confirmed) while conspicuously withholding the power plant strikes that would pull the Houthis' Bab el-Mandeb trigger. Iran answered with its widest barrage of the war, hitting US linked targets in seven countries and crossing its own threshold: a strike that set Kuwait's Shuaiba power and desalination complex on fire, the first Iranian hit on Gulf civilian infrastructure in this round. Brent settled up 4.6% at $88.10, over 10% on the week. Diplomacy produced nothing — Tehran denied any planned talks and IRGC elder Mohsen Rezaei set a "two or three day" clock to "full scale offensive operations." Korean markets were closed Friday for Constitution Day, so the week ended with the won at ₩1,480.4 — its first sub 1,490 weekly close, logged without intervention — and Monday's reopening now faces two days of accumulated shock: the oil spike, the Gulf infrastructure exchange, and an LNG lifeline out of Ras Laffan that has been frozen since July 11.

---

1. What Happened

1.1 The US Strikes Six Bridges and Port Infrastructure, Executing Half the Ultimatum Early

On the war's seventh consecutive night the US hit "dozens of Iranian military facilities," and for the first time transport infrastructure named in Trump's ultimatum: six bridges in Hormozgan province (including one on the Bandar Abbas–Shiraz route and bridges at Bandar Khamir), a railway junction in Bandar Abbas, Iranshahr airport, and the maritime control tower at Chabahar port, which was collapsed; a senior US official told the Wall Street Journal the aim is to cut supply routes into Bandar Abbas, home of the IRGC naval base (NPR, NBC, Al Jazeera, Washington Times). Iran's Energy Ministry acknowledged damage to power lines and asked southern provinces to cut electricity use — but full power plant strikes have not begun, with Trump saying he would "save the energy targets for last" (Al Jazeera, Euronews). IRNA reported 7–8 killed and about 20 wounded in the latest wave; Iranian health officials put the week's toll at 38 killed, 400+ wounded. **Confidence: High** on the strike set (CENTCOM statement plus Iranian state media locations, corroborated across outlets); **Medium** on casualties (single party Iranian figures).

1.2 Iran Answers Across Seven Countries and Sets Kuwait's Water Plant Ablaze

Iran said it targeted US military sites in Bahrain, Jordan, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar and Syria — with drones also downed over Erbil in Iraq — in the 12th to 15th waves of "Operation Nasr 2," its widest single day barrage of the war (Al Jazeera, Middle East Monitor). The day's threshold event: Kuwait intercepted 6 missiles and 33 drones but a strike set fire to a power generation and water desalination station (reported as Shuaiba), damaging "a large number" of generating units — the first Iranian hit on a Gulf state's civilian infrastructure, in a country where desalination supplies ~90% of drinking water (Bloomberg, The National, IranWire). Qatar intercepted two pre-dawn missile waves aimed at Al-Udeid (a child was hurt by falling shrapnel), Jordan downed three missiles, and CENTCOM rejected as "false" the IRGC's claim to have struck a US command center at al-Tanf in Syria (Euronews, Petra, Jerusalem Post). Mohsen Rezaei — top IRGC figure and military adviser to Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei —

warned on state TV: “If US attacks continue for another two or three days, we will enter a phase of full scale offensive operations.” Brent settled at $88.10 (+4.6%) and WTI at $82.49 (+4.5%), both up more than 10% on the week, with the Kuwait strike the cited catalyst (CNBC). **Confidence: High** on the Kuwait strike (government statement) and oil settles; **Medium** on IRGC target claims and the Rezaei framing.

1.3 No Meeting Materializes as Tehran Denies Talks

A day after Trump said Iran “wants to meet,” no meeting, venue or date was announced, and Iran’s foreign ministry position remains on the record: “We currently have no plans for negotiations and are focused on defense,” with Tehran saying it no longer considers itself bound by the June MOU while attacks continue (Press TV, ANI). No second detainee release or goodwill gesture followed Dena Karari’s; the active channels are Qatari, Pakistani and Egyptian mediation, which regional officials say continued through Friday’s escalation (Middle East Online). On the US side, Times of Israel cited reports that Trump is leaning toward a major expansion of the offensive after a Situation Room review of previously unstruck strategic targets; publicly he said “I don’t like giving deadlines, but they pretty much know… They better behave” (Times of Israel, Fox News). **Confidence: High** on the Iranian denial and the absence of any announced meeting; **Medium** on the Situation Room reporting (attributed leaks).

1.4 The LNG Lifeline Freezes: No Laden Carrier Out of Hormuz Since July 11

Kpler data show no LNG carrier has transited Hormuz since ADNOC’s Al Hamra on July 11 — and that was a UAE cargo, not Qatari; as of midweek 21 LNG carriers sat inside the Gulf (13 ballast, 5 laden but not transiting, 4 berthed, two of them at Ras Laffan), meaning loading continues but nothing is getting out (LNG Prime, Kpler). QatarEnergy has extended force majeure toward Italy’s Edison to mid September — 21 cancelled cargoes April through September — while the mid July lapse of force majeure that Asian buyers expected remains unconfirmed (AGBI, Bloomberg). The wider strait picture matches: 8 transits Thursday with only 3 commodity vessels (fewest since May) on Kpler’s count via CNBC, hull war risk premiums at 3–10% of vessel value versus 0.25% pre-war, and some shippers refusing US military guided convoys after escorted ships were attacked (CNBC, The National, US News/Reuters). At Bab el-Mandeb, the other threatened artery, there was no attack and no closure declaration — the Houthis limited Friday to “Warning and Mobilization” marches, and the Joint Maritime Information Center said it saw no “operational indicators or targeting activity” — while the EU reinforced its Aspides naval mission with a Djibouti basing accord (Euronews, FDD/Long War Journal). **Confidence: High** on the LNG transit freeze and war risk levels; **Medium** on the Asian force majeure status; **High** on the absence of a Red Sea incident.

1.5 Israel Dissolves the Knesset for October Elections as the Lebanon Meeting Slips

Israel’s parliament dissolved Friday, setting elections for October 27 and making Netanyahu’s the first government in nearly five decades to complete a full term; the final legislative blitz expanded government regulatory power over media, froze arrests of ultra-Orthodox draft evaders, and disclosed a previously secret 1.3 billion shekel allocation toward 34 West Bank settlements (Al Jazeera, The National, CNN). The same day, the US sponsored Lebanese–Israeli military meeting meant to finalize the pilot withdrawal zones was postponed at Washington’s request to complete “technical files,” with a Lebanese security source telling The National “the Israelis are stalling”; a reschedule around July 23 would coincide with a visit by US Gen. Joseph Clearfield (The National, Naharnet, Asharq Al-Awsat). On the ground the Lebanese army reinforced Froun and Burj Qlaouiyeh while the IDF carried out a large controlled explosion near Zawtar el-Gharbiyeh — one of the pilot villages — and struck near Tyre and Nabatieh; local reporting suggests the second pilot zone, around Zawtar al-Sharqiyeh, does contain positions the IDF actually holds (Times of Israel liveblog, MTV Lebanon, Middle East Eye). **Confidence: High** on the dissolution and the postponement; **Medium** on the “stalling” attribution and the second zone detail.

---

2. Deep Dive: Incentives and Motives

2.1 Why hit the bridges five days early, and why not the grid?

The early execution solves Washington's credibility problem and preserves its leverage in one move. Striking bridges now — before the stated "next week" — demonstrates the ultimatum is not the toll episode repeated, collapses Tehran's planning assumption of a padded July 22 date, and degrades the logistics (Bandar Abbas resupply) Iran would need for the retaliation it is promising. But note what was withheld: the power plants are the single named trigger of Iran's standing order to the Houthis, and Trump's "save the energy targets for last" keeps that rung of the ladder unclimbed. This is deadline ambiguity as strategy — "I don't like giving deadlines" converts a fixed tripwire into a continuous threat, harder to hedge and harder to pre-empt. The risk sits in Tehran's classification, not Washington's: Iran's Energy Ministry is already reporting damaged power lines and asking provinces to cut consumption, so the distinction between "logistics targets" and "the power network" that US planners are threading may not survive contact with Iranian perception. If IRGC officers in Yemen read grid damage where CENTCOM sees collateral, the Bab el-Mandeb trigger fires on a misread — which is why IND-20260718-1 tracks the grid line explicitly.

2.2 What does striking Kuwait's water supply change?

It makes the hostage taking symmetric. Washington holds Iran's civilian infrastructure at risk; as of Friday, Iran demonstrably holds the Gulf's — and chose the most existential asset class available, water, in a state where ~90% of drinking supply is desalinated. The immediate purpose is coercive burden shifting: Gulf capitals hosting US forces are being told their utilities are the collateral for Washington's next escalation, which converts them from bystanders lobbying for restraint into hostages with an urgent interest in stopping the grid strikes. But the move cuts against two Iranian interests at once. It burns exactly the mediation channels (Qatar, Kuwait itself) that constitute Iran's only off-ramp conduit, and it validates the hawks' case inside Gulf capitals that hedging has failed — note the still unverified but persistent reporting of UAE participation in strikes on Iran (IND-20260715-3). Markets read the strike correctly: the 4.6% move on Brent is the war premium extending from Iranian supply to the Gulf's own export and utility systems. If Shuaiba style strikes repeat, the pricing question stops being "how much Iranian oil is lost" and becomes "is Gulf infrastructure itself in the target set" — a categorically larger risk premium that Korea imports directly through its energy bill.

2.3 Is the diplomatic exit closed?

Narrowing, not closed. The honest ledger: no meeting announced, an on the record Iranian denial, no second goodwill gesture, and a US president reportedly reviewing expansion options — every observable points away from the off-ramp that Wednesday's detainee release seemed to open, and IND-20260717-1 now has five days to its deadline. Yet two facts argue the exit is still ajar. The Gulf mediation channels survived Friday's barrage — Qatar took two missile waves at Al-Udeid and kept mediating — and Iran's escalation retains a bargaining structure: Rezaei's "two or three days" formulation is itself a deadline offered to be beaten, the mirror of Trump's "they better behave." Both sides are still escalating *toward* a table, each believing the other must fold first — the classic war termination trap in which the meeting happens only after one more round each side believes will be decisive. The analytical implication is unchanged from yesterday but sharper: de-escalation remains the underpriced tail, and its trigger will look sudden — a Gulf brokered pause announced with no visible preparation — precisely because both sides need to deny wanting it until the moment it exists.

2.4 Why is LNG trapped when crude found workarounds?

Because geography gives crude options that LNG does not have. Korea's crude adaptation worked through substitution: non Hormuz barrels (273 million secured), a Red Sea detour (14 tankers now), US and Kazakh grades, and reserve releases. Qatari LNG has no equivalent — Ras Laffan sits at the bottom of the Gulf with Hormuz as its only exit, no pipeline bypass, and a specialized carrier fleet whose hulls are too valuable to insure through a shooting gallery: at 3–10% war risk on a $250 million vessel, a single round trip costs more in premium than the cargo margin. The result is the queue Kpler describes — loading continues, five laden carriers idle inside the Gulf, nothing transits — which is not a production halt but a shipping market verdict. That distinction matters for Korea: the gas exists, the trains are running (six showing thermal signatures), and the moment insurance or escort economics change, flow can resume within days. But until then Korea's Qatar share (~14% of LNG imports) is supplied from inventories, swaps (KOGAS is seeking Atlantic for Pacific exchanges) and spot cover — and the contractual layer is quietly hardening against buyers, with force majeure extended to mid September for Edison and the promised Asian lapse unconfirmed. IND-20260717-2's deadline (July 24) will likely resolve on insurance economics, not on Qatari intent.

2.5 What does an October election do to Israel's war tracks?

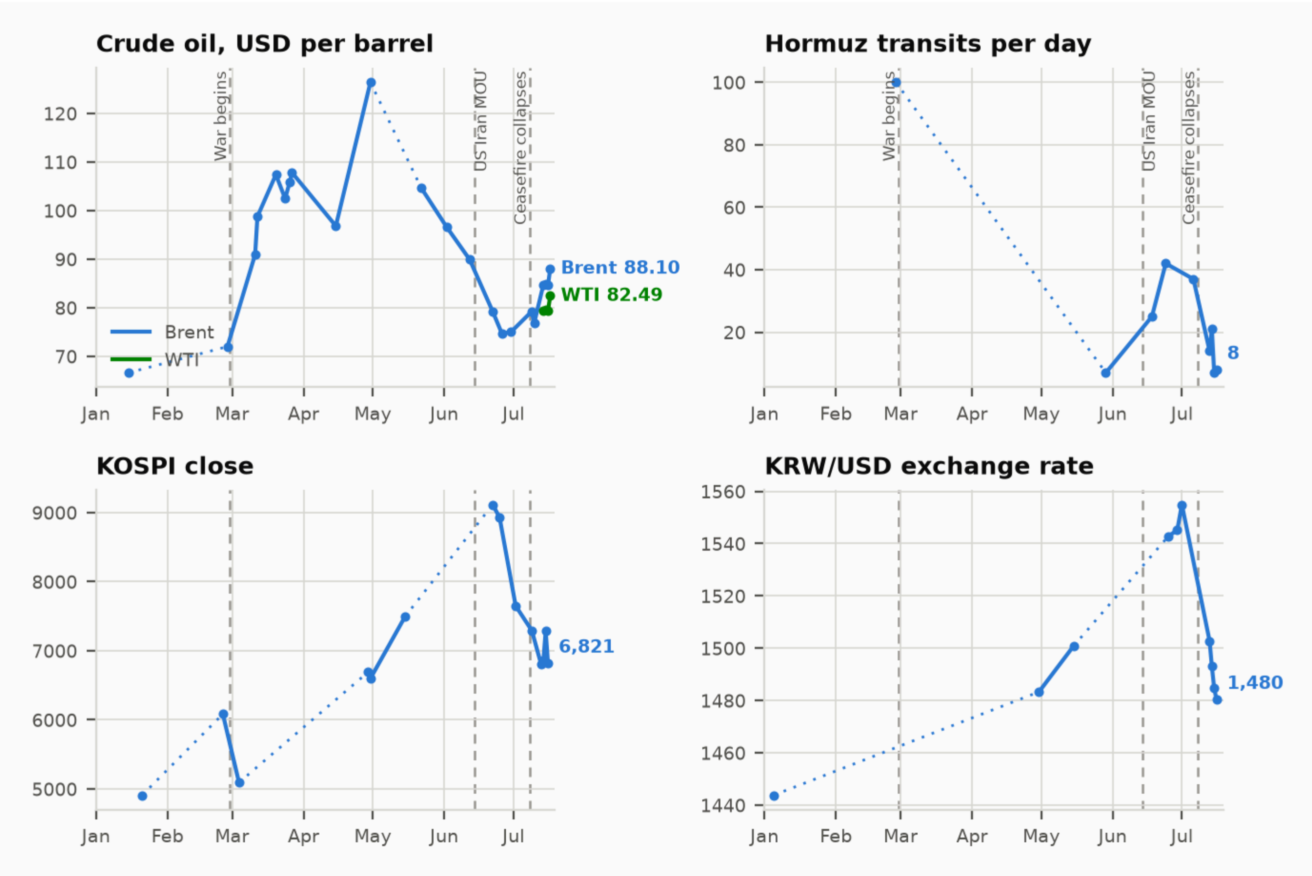
It time stamps every negotiation. From Friday, each Israeli concession — a Lebanon withdrawal with real content, a Gaza phase two package, any daylight with Washington on Iran — carries an October 27 price tag, and the campaign logic of a coalition that just legislated expanded media control and settlement funding is to defer costs and bank optics. That reframes the Lebanon postponement: whether or not "the Israelis are stalling" is literally true this week, stalling is now structurally rewarded until October, and the pilot zone framework's unfailable first step (zones Israel never held) fits an election season need for progress theater exactly. The July 23 rescheduled meeting doubles as the test of Washington's counter leverage: the Clearfield visit signals the US intends to force the zone list to include territory the IDF actually occupies (Zawtar al-Sharqiyeh), which would make withdrawal cost something and therefore reveal whether the track survives contact with campaign incentives. Gaza reads the same: strikes at the highest tempo since the truce, phase two frozen, and now an electorate as the primary audience. For this briefing's sourcing, Israeli official claims through October carry a campaign discount — and reconstruction linked procurement stays frozen at least that long.

2.6 What will Monday's reopening in Seoul have to price?

Two days of shock, in one session, against a policy anchor set on Thursday. Korean markets were closed Friday for Constitution Day — the holiday's first observance since reinstatement — so Monday July 20 opens against: the aftermath of Thursday's chip led 6.37% rout, Friday's 4.6% oil spike to $88.10, the first Iranian strike on Gulf civilian infrastructure, and an LNG lifeline frozen for a week. The stabilizers are real but narrow. The BOK's hawkish turn is now explicit — Governor Shin Hyun-song vowed hikes "until inflation returns to 2%," the statement wrote in a tightening bias for the first time, and surveys see 3.00% by year end — which supports the won through rate differentials; the won's ₩1,480.4 weekly close (logged without intervention, Friday being a holiday) is the first of IND-20260715-4's two falsification closes. Meanwhile the F4 authorities spent Thursday evening on the leveraged ETF mechanics that have amplified every 2026 selloff. The clean read: Korea's FX and equity channels have decoupled — FX anchored by policy, equities exposed to both the chip cycle and the war. Monday tests whether that decoupling holds under a compound gap; IND-20260718-3 gives it thresholds.

---

3. Policy Implications for South Korea



Korea's structural exposure baselines are in `instructions/korea-exposure.md` (~70% of crude and ~36% of LNG through Hormuz, ~273m non Hormuz barrels secured, ~26 day reserve estimate). Three updates were made to that file today: the Red Sea detour count rose to 14 tankers with the Ministry of Oceans and Fisheries confirming the latest transit (loaded at Yanbu, Saudi Arabia), September crude procurement stands 76% secured as of July 14, and KOGAS's Atlantic for Pacific cargo swap seeking was added to the mitigation table (Korea Times, Seoul Economic Daily, Argus). **Confidence: High.**

The day's Korea specific readings:

- **Markets:** Closed Friday July 17 for Constitution Day (first observance since the holiday's reinstatement); trading resumes Monday July 20. The weekly closes therefore stand at Thursday's levels: KOSPI 6,820.60 (−6.37% Thursday), won ₩1,480.4. Offshore the won traded ~₩1,480.8 Friday — thin prints, as 24 hour won trading launched only July 6 (IBTimes, Trading Economics). **Confidence: High** on the closure and weekly closes; **Medium** on the offshore print.
- **Policy:** Governor Shin Hyun-song: hikes "until inflation returns to 2%"; the BOK statement carried an explicit continuing tightening stance for the first time, oil driven inflation effects expected to last "at least a year," year end rate seen at 3.00%; the F4 authorities met on leveraged ETF curbs (minimum deposits, dispersed rebalancing) after the products were blamed for doubling the frequency of ±3% KOSPI days (Seoul Economic Daily, KED Global). No new FX intervention, verbal or actual, was found in the window. **Confidence: High** on the BOK stance; **Medium-High** on the intervention absence.
- **Oil:** Brent settled $88.10 (+4.6%), WTI $82.49 (+4.5%), both up more than 10% on the week — the sharpest weekly rise since the war's June escalation, driven by the Kuwait plant strike and Red Sea closure risk (CNBC). Note the spike reverses Korea's recent disinflation tailwind (June import prices fell 4.4% m/m on

the earlier oil slump). **Confidence: High** on WTI; **Medium** on the Brent settle print (single primary source; Trading Economics showed $85.95 intraday).

Implications by development:

1. **Early bridge strikes (1.1):** The market's refusal to price the ultimatum is over — partially. With execution begun early and the grid deliberately withheld, deadline risk is no longer a point event on July 22 but a continuous variable; Korean risk desks should stop treating the July 20–24 window as the risk and start treating any single headline about Iranian power plants as the trigger. The Bandar Abbas logistics damage also degrades Iran's ability to sustain the Iranian route corridor that most remaining Hormuz transits use.
2. **Kuwait plant strike (1.2):** Gulf civilian infrastructure is now in the demonstrated target set, and Korea's exposure to that class is direct: Ras Laffan, Kuwaiti refineries under Korean E&C contracts, and above all Barakah — KEPCO's four reactors and Korean staff sit in a country Iran struck again Friday (Al Dhafra). The Barakah question — what happens to Korea's largest overseas energy asset if the UAE's participation reports harden — should move from background to active contingency planning now.
3. **Diplomacy (1.3):** IND-20260717-1 has five days. The asymmetric hedge logic stands (de-escalation remains the underpriced tail), but its window is closing: if the deadline passes unresolved, the executed ultimatum branch — with the coupled Houthi trigger — takes the probability mass and the cheap de-escalation optionality is gone.
4. **LNG freeze (1.4):** Korea's Q4 procurement gap is now the base case, not the risk case, unless insurance economics or the Asian force majeure decision break favorably by IND-20260717-2's July 24 deadline. Act while the queue persists: Atlantic spot cover and swap execution before competing Asian buyers price the same conclusion; watch the helium side channel (~65% Qatari) for semiconductor inputs.
5. **Israel's election clock (1.5):** Lebanon reconstruction procurement and any Gaza stabilization tender are frozen at least through October 27; Korean E&C bidding pipelines should assume no bankable framework this year. Score the July 23 meeting by one criterion: does the finalized zone list include Zawtar al-Sharqiyeh or any position the IDF physically holds (IND-20260716-3).
6. **Monday reopening (2.6):** Watch three prints in sequence: the 9:00 open for a compound gap (20th sidecar risk), the won against ₩1,490, and closing breadth — whether oil sensitive names (utilities, airlines, chemicals) sell off independently of the chip complex. The BOK anchor argues for FX resilience; the equity channel has no equivalent anchor.

Testable indicators:

1. **IND-20260718-1: The grid trigger stays unpulled or fires.** Confirmation: verified US strikes on Iranian power generation plants or the national grid proper (beyond the July 17 line damage) by ~July 24 — expect immediate Bab el-Mandeb activation risk via the standing Houthi order (IND-20260716-2 couples), and reprice both arteries simultaneously. Falsification: the campaign continues on bridges, ports and logistics through July 24 with energy targets still withheld — "save the energy targets for last" is a maintained rung on the ladder, and the two artery shock stays conditional rather than imminent.
2. **IND-20260718-2: Rezaei's countdown produces a new phase or expires as rhetoric.** Confirmation: by ~July 21, Iran opens a qualitatively new phase — mass attacks on commercial shipping, strikes on Gulf energy export facilities beyond Shuaiba, Bab el-Mandeb activation, or a strike producing US casualties. Falsification: the window passes at the existing exchange tempo — the "two or three days" line was

mobilization rhetoric for a domestic audience, and Iranian escalation remains calibrated below the thresholds that would force maximum US response.

3. **IND-20260718-3: Monday in Seoul absorbs the two shock gap without breaking the anchors.** Confirmation: the July 20 session closes better than −4% on the KOSPI and the won closes at or below ₩1,490 without intervention — the policy anchor holds and Korea's financial channel stays contained despite the compound gap. Falsification: a close worse than −4% or a won close back above ₩1,490 — the gap overwhelmed the anchor, the FX equity decoupling failed, and the financial crisis channel (IND-20260715-4) reopens. Deadline: July 20 Seoul close.

Open indicator status from the ledger: IND-20260714-4 (no weekly loading figure again; exports zero since July 11, thermal activity down to six trains — open), IND-20260715-1 (8 transits July 16 with 3 commodity vessels; the recovery test is effectively failed with its ~July 21 deadline in three days; the sub 20/day regime track runs toward confirmation ~July 27 — open; note Kpler counting bases remain inconsistent, with the same CNBC series putting July 15 at 15 versus AP's 7), IND-20260715-2 (no named Gulf package — open), IND-20260715-3 (unverified reporting of UAE participation in strikes on Iran, plus Iran's stated rationale for targeting Al Dhafra; below the corroboration bar, seeking Tier 1/2 confirmation — open), IND-20260715-4 (first weekly close test met on the falsification side: ₩1,480.4, no intervention; one more sub 1,490 close on July 24 falsifies the crisis channel — open), IND-20260716-1 (**confirmed July 17**: six bridges struck within the deadline, power lines damaged — the civilian infrastructure phase is real; announced above), IND-20260716-2 (no verified incident; JMIC sees no operational indicators; the declared grid trigger remains unpulled — open), IND-20260716-3 (meeting postponed to ~July 23 against a ~July 26 deadline; no withdrawal; score against Zawtar al-Sharqiyeh if the list lands — open), IND-20260717-1 (no announced meeting; Iran denies talks — open, trending falsification), IND-20260717-2 (zero laden Hormuz exits since July 11, five laden carriers idle inside the Gulf — open, trending falsification; score departures by Gulf exit, not berth departure), IND-20260717-3 (August BOK meeting; Thursday's statement language already embeds the war — open).

---

4. Watch List

- **Gaza's funeral strike and the frozen phase two:** An Israeli drone strike hit a funeral gathering in Nuseirat — for a victim of an earlier strike the same day — killing 7–8 and wounding 20+, within a Friday toll of at least 12; the IDF said it targeted an Islamic Jihad cell and was "aware that civilians may have been harmed." No Cairo movement; 1,100+ killed since the truce (AP/US News, Reuters/WHBL, The National). **Confidence: High.**
- **The July 20–24 convergence window, restacked:** Rezaei's countdown (~July 20–21), IND-20260717-1's diplomacy deadline (~July 23), the rescheduled Lebanon meeting and Clearfield visit (~July 23), IND-20260717-2's LNG deadline (~July 24), and the grid strike question (IND-20260718-1, ~July 24) now all land in one five day span. **Confidence: High** on the calendar; the coupling logic is unchanged.
- **UAE belligerence reports:** Secondary sourcing (including Iran's own targeting rationale for Al Dhafra) describes UAE airstrikes on Iran in coordination with the US and Israel. If a Tier 1/2 outlet confirms, IND-20260715-3 resolves as the first Gulf shift from hedging to belligerence — with direct implications for Barakah and Korean nationals in the UAE. **Confidence: Low** pending corroboration.
- **The Saudi front and Korea's detour:** Abdul-Malik al-Houthi's speech threatened Saudi Arabia with "airports for airports, ports for ports, blockade for blockade" amid Sanaa–Abha exchanges. Korea's Red Sea workaround loads at Yanbu — a Saudi Red Sea port inside that threat envelope; a Saudi–Houthi escalation

would threaten the detour route from a second direction even without a Bab el-Mandeb closure (Eurasia Review). **Confidence: Medium.**

- **Qatar’s Asian force majeure decision:** Asian buyers expected the lapse in mid July; the Edison extension to mid September points the other way. The formal decision, when it lands, sets whether Korea’s Q4 gap is contractual or just logistical. **Confidence: Medium.**
- **Weekend Seoul catch up:** No MOFA or NSC statement on the Gulf strikes surfaced Friday — plausibly holiday publication lag. Expect weekend statements (and possibly emergency energy meetings) before the Monday open; their tone is a free read on how Seoul weighs the Kuwait precedent. **Confidence: Medium.**
- **Mojtaba Khamenei’s continued invisibility:** Still no public appearance; the war’s public voice is IRGC (Rezaei, identified as his military adviser) — consistent with IRGC primacy in decision making, including the Yemen trigger. **Confidence: Medium.**

---

5. Source Quality Summary

Claim	Sources	Confidence
US struck six bridges, Bandar Abbas rail junction, Iranshahr airport, Chabahar tower	CENTCOM statement, Iranian state media; NPR, NBC, Al Jazeera, Washington Times	High
Purpose: cutting supply routes into Bandar Abbas	Senior US official to WSJ, via NBC	Medium
Iran Energy Ministry: power lines damaged, southern provinces asked to cut use	Iranian Energy Ministry statement; Al Jazeera, Euronews	High
Trump: “save the energy targets for last”; no power plant strikes yet	Direct quotes; multi outlet; Forbes wording to the contrary treated as unreliable	High
Iranian casualties: 7–8 killed latest wave; 38 killed/400+ wounded on week	IRNA, Iranian health officials (single party)	Medium
Iran struck US linked targets in six countries plus Erbil drones	Al Jazeera, MEMO, Kuwaiti/Qatari/Jordanian government statements	High
Kuwait power and desalination station hit, fire, generating units damaged	Kuwaiti ministry statement; Bloomberg, The National, IranWire	High
Al-Udeid missile waves intercepted; child hurt by shrapnel	Qatari government; Euronews, Reuters via Internazionale	High
CENTCOM rejects IRGC al-Tanf claim as “false”	CENTCOM; JPost, MEE	High
Rezaei: “full scale offensive operations” in “two or three days”	IRIB state TV quote; CNN, Al Jazeera	High
No US-Iran meeting announced; Iran: “no plans for negotiations”	Iranian FM spokesman on record; Press TV, ANI	High
Trump leaning toward major expansion after Situation Room review	Attributed leaks; Times of Israel	Medium
No LNG carrier through Hormuz since July 11; 21 carriers inside Gulf	Kpler data; LNG Prime, Kpler blog	High
QatarEnergy force majeure extended to mid September for Edison (21 cargoes)	AGBI	Medium
Hormuz: 8 transits July 16, 3 commodity vessels, fewest since May	Kpler via CNBC (counting bases still inconsistent vs AP series)	Medium
War risk premiums 3–10% of hull vs 0.25% pre-war	The National, Lloyd’s List	High
No Bab el-Mandeb attack or closure declaration; JMIC sees no indicators	JMIC statement; FDD/LWJ, Euronews	High
EU reinforced Aspides with Djibouti accord	Kallas visit; Euronews	High
Knesset dissolved; October 27 elections; legislative blitz details	Al Jazeera, The National, CNN, JPost, ToI	High

Claim	Sources	Confidence
Lebanon military meeting postponed; “Israelis are stalling”; ~July 23 reschedule	The National, Naharnet, Asharq Al-Awsat, Arab News	High
Second pilot zone (Zawtar al-Sharqiyeh) contains actual IDF positions	ToI liveblog, local reporting	Medium
Nuseirat funeral strike: 7–8 killed, 20+ wounded; ≥12 killed Friday	AP + Reuters, medics; The National, MEMO	High
Korean markets closed for Constitution Day; weekly closes stand at Thursday’s	KRX notice via IBTimes, Sedaily, Korea Times	High
Won weekly close ₩1,480.4, no intervention; offshore ~₩1,480.8 Friday	Trading Economics, Businesskorea (Thu close); absence of intervention across searches	High (close) / Medium (offshore, no intervention)
Shin Hyun-song: hikes “until inflation returns to 2%”; year end 3.00% seen	Sedaily, KED Global survey, KJD	High
Brent settle $88.10 +4.6%; WTI $82.49 +4.5%; week +10%	CNBC settlements (TE intraday conflicts on Brent)	High (WTI) / Medium (Brent)
14th Korean tanker completed Red Sea transit (loaded at Yanbu)	Ministry of Oceans and Fisheries; Korea Times, KJD	High
UAE participation in strikes on Iran	Wikipedia war article, Iranian targeting rationale — uncorroborated by Tier 1/2	Low

Generated 2026-07-18 (KST) from web research across 30+ outlets (US, Qatari, Saudi/UAE, Israeli, Lebanese, Iranian state and opposition, Korean, European, specialist energy and shipping press).